sufficiently conciliatory frame of mind. Bahadur Shah did not send a message of condolence to the Mughal prince on the death of his brother, as would have been expected, nor did he come down from his imposing fortress at Asirgarh to receive Daniyal. Unimpressed with this behaviour, Daniyal proposed attacking Bahadur Shah immediately but Akbar, waiting with the bulk of the imperial forces at Ujjain, forbade him from doing so and decided to march to Burhanpur himself.

The erosion of Bahadur Shah's amity towards the Mughals had occurred because of the tragic fate of his father, Raja Ali Khan of Khandesh. With his small kingdom of Khandesh surrounded by powerful neighbours such as Gujarat, Malwa, Ahmadnagar and then, the Mughals, Ali Khan had had to play a dangerous and constantly evolving game of brinkmanship between these various parties. Torn between his allegiance to the Deccani cause, and the pragmatic reality of Mughal might, the raja finally decided to help the Mughals during one of their battles against Chand Sultan and died fighting for the Mughals. Unfortunately for Khandesh, though, the Mughals were unaware of the raja's sacrifice. As his body lay unclaimed on the sodden battlefield, the Mughals decided that his sudden disappearance signalled traitorous abdication to the Deccani faction, and plundered and looted his camp and possessions. When his body was discovered among the fallen, 'the evil-thoughted and the foolish talkers were ashamed', scolded Abu'l Fazl. The Mughals restored the raja's banners and kettledrums hurriedly and buried his body with full honours in Burhanpur. But the damage had been done and the raja's son, Bahadur Shah, now seethed at the idea of submission to Akbar.

News of Bahadur Shah's defiance had been conveyed to Akbar through Abu'l Fazl, whom the Padshah had summoned to Ujjain from Ahmadnagar. Pleased to see his old friend after an unusually long absence, Akbar raised Abu'l Fazl to a mansab of 5,000 so that this loyal but often maligned and criticized courtier could write with satisfaction of his critics that 'many sate down in the blackness of envy'.

Akbar, Abu'l Fazl, and the Mughal travelling camp now left Ujjain, and made their way south, cutting a path through the hills of the Satpura range. The accompanying Jesuit priests struggled to maintain their routine of prayers in this 'confusion worse than Babylon' but thanks to a 'portable church', they reassured their readers of being able to celebrate mass satisfactorily while on the road. When they reached Burhanpur, Akbar sent